

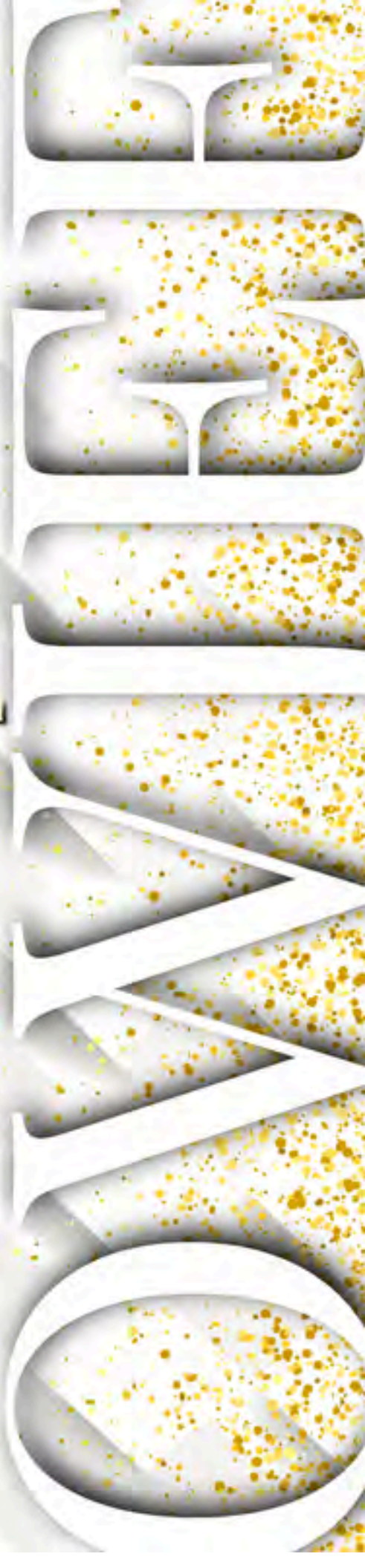


ANNUAL SCHOLARSHIP GALA

SATURDAY
APRIL 11th 2026

MIDTOWN EVENT CENTER

6221 Colonel Glenn Rd A, Little Rock, AR 72204







9th ANNUAL SCHOLARSHIP GALA

IN HONOR OF

Oscar Washington Jr.

The Oscar David Washington, Jr. Scholarship stands as a powerful reflection of both legacy and purpose—two values that deeply align with the mission of the OWJEF (Oscar Washington Jr. Education Fund). Established by family and friends, this scholarship honors a man whose life embodied excellence, leadership, and unwavering service to others.

Oscar David Washington, Jr. was a distinguished scholar and servant leader. A 1986 graduate of Carlisle High School and a 1990 graduate of the University of Central Arkansas, he went on to earn a Master's degree in Business from the University of Arkansas at Little Rock and became a Certified Public Accountant. His commitment to service extended beyond his professional achievements, as he proudly served as a Captain in the Arkansas Army National Guard, 39th Infantry Brigade.

Professionally, Oscar broke barriers and led with integrity, serving as Vice President of Customer Service at Entergy Arkansas. His entrepreneurial spirit was evident through his ownership of ODS Enterprises, LLC, Gold Medal Flooring, and Genesis Construction. Yet, beyond his titles and accolades, Oscar was most recognized for his heart—his ability to lead, uplift, and pour into others.

A devoted disciple of Christ, Oscar faithfully served as a Deacon at Saint Mark Baptist Church in Little Rock, Arkansas. His life was marked by a deep commitment to community, mentorship, and service. He gave his time and leadership to organizations such as Alpha Phi Alpha Fraternity, Inc., Big Brothers Big Sisters of Pulaski County, Pulaski Technical College, the University of Central Arkansas Alumni Association, the Arkansas Home Builders Association, the American Heart Association, and many more.

It is this spirit of excellence and service that the OWJEF continues to carry forward. As an organization, OWJEF is dedicated to investing in the next generation of leaders by providing scholarships, mentorship, and opportunities that empower students to succeed academically and lead with purpose. Through initiatives like this scholarship, the foundation not only honors Oscar's legacy but actively builds the future he believed in—one where education, faith, and community intersect.

PROGRAM

Welcome Video

Greetings & Acknowledgements..... Pamela Smith, Host

Prayer Pastor Justin Bilson

Dinner

Introduction of Speaker

Speaker Ebony Mitchell

Video Presentation

Presentation of Awards..... Beth Hunt

Video Presentation

Presentation of Students.....Sydni Hood
Stephanie Washington

Video Presentation

Appeal.....Michael Manning

Closing Remarks.....Doris Washington
Mark Leverett

Closing Prayer..... Rev. Judy Rudd



Dr. Lloyd Jackson

As a trailblazing educator, he has spent 20 years rising from classroom teacher to superintendent. As the first Black superintendent in the Texarkana Arkansas School District, he leads with vision, purpose, and a deep commitment to students and community. Being a first-generation college graduate, he continues to champion education as a pathway to opportunity alongside his wife, Dr. Veronica Jackson.

Phylicia Hollis Butler

An educator, musician, author, and servant-leader, she inspires through both the arts and education. As Choral Director and Piano Instructor at Jacksonville High School, she develops students in confidence, discipline, and artistry.

A published author and active community leader, she serves with excellence alongside her husband, Pastor Marcus Butler.

Ann Freeman

A cornerstone of early childhood education in Arkansas, she brings 40 years of dedication to young learners. As Building Administrator of Rockefeller Early Childhood Center, she has led the school to the state's highest quality rating and toward national accreditation.

Her leadership is rooted in a deep commitment to children and families. She is married to Barney Freeman and is the proud mother of Maya Freeman.

Capri Bell Salaam

An award-winning Arkansas educator, she was named the 2023 Arkansas Teacher of the Year and now serves as State Director for Education Renewal Zones at the Arkansas Department of Education. She is expanding opportunities for students and teachers across the state.

A doctoral candidate in educational leadership, she leads with heart and purpose alongside her husband, Tauheed, and their three children.

Kyron Jones

As a relationship-driven educator with over 30 years of service, he has impacted students and schools across Arkansas in roles from teacher to Principal and state leader. Since 2018, he has served as COO of Academics Plus Charter Schools and will become CEO in July 2026. Guided by a belief in authentic relationships, he continues to lead with purpose alongside his wife, Tonya, and their daughter, Peyton.



2026 The Alma J. Washington EDUCATORS OF THE YEAR

O

UP Scholarship RECIPIENTS

Whitley Rogers

With a 4.4 GPA and one of the most recruited athletes in the state, she received 20+ Division I offers before choosing to be an Arkansas Razorback. She is the 2024 Arkansas Gatorade Player of the Year and a McDonald's All-American Nominee.



Damien Wicker

With a 4.3 GPA and a 35 ACT score, he is a 2025 4A Wrestling State Champion, Senior Class Secretary, and member of both National Honor Society and National Spanish Honor Society—setting the standard for achievement and leadership.



Morgan Perry

With a 4.3 GPA, she is the Founder and CEO of M.E. Marie, and an award-winning student leader. As Student Council Chairwoman and DECA President, Morgan plans to major in Finance and continue building a future rooted in leadership and innovation.



August Oliver

With a 3.9 GPA and 35 ACT score, he was selected for the Arkansas Governor's School for Mathematics and serves on the Arkansas Children's Hospital Youth Advisory Council. August plans to major in Biological Science.



Za'Niya Hawkins

With a 4.2 GPA, 28 ACT score, and honors including AP Scholar with Distinction and national recognition, Za'Niya consistently excels at the highest level. As Student Council President and founder of Girl2Girl, she leads while uplifting others.



Madison Morris

As a dedicated and driven student she is a National Honor Society member and Arkansas Girls State participant. She plans to pursue a degree in Nursing and make a meaningful impact in healthcare.



Neema Patel

An 11th grader with a 4.3 GPA and enough credits to graduate early, she holds 176 hours of community service and national recognition for her leadership. Headed to the University of Central Arkansas to study Nursing, Neema is prepared for what's next—arriving with purpose and ahead of schedule.



Jaxon Owoh

As a Top Teens of America Vice President and Arkansas Boys State, State Representative, Jaxon has already proven he's a leader—ready to build a future that makes an impact. He's headed to the University of Arkansas at Fayetteville to study Civil Engineering.



OUR Scholarship RECIPIENTS

Heidy Umanzor

As a first-generation college student, she's headed to Arkansas State University to study Pharmacy with a mission to serve her community. As a Seal of Biliteracy recipient, she is dedicated to creating meaningful impact through education and service.



Timothy Johnson

Timothy is driven, disciplined, and focused. He balances academics, leadership, and entrepreneurship while also shining as a 2025 6A State Basketball Champion. He plans to study Computer Science and is already committed to serving his community.



Avery Marvin

As the Salutatorian, Avery graduates with a 4.3 GPA, AP Scholar with Distinction honors, and membership in National Honor Society. She also serves on the NLR Mayor's Youth Council, bringing leadership and voice to her community.



Ariana Morris

With a 4.1 GPA and member of the National Honor Society, she brings focus and purpose to her work and service. She will attend the University of Central Arkansas to study Graphic Design and Marketing, continuing to combine artistry and strategy as she moves forward.



Ashlee Hill

Ranked #4 in her class, she has demonstrated excellence in both academics and service. A member of National Honor Society, Arkansas Girls State, and UAMS Pathways Academy, she is already preparing for a future in healthcare.



Steven Robinowitz

With a 4.0 GPA, 28 ACT score, and over 100 hours of community service, he has built a strong foundation for his future. He plans to study History and Psychology on his path to becoming a high school teacher.



Kennedy Wilson

With a 4.1 GPA and a 28 ACT score, she is excelling at the highest level. A State Volleyball Champion and All-Conference selection, she stands out across elite programs and competitions. Beyond athletics, she has dedicated over 184 hours to community service and is committed to Baylor University for Acrobatics & Tumbling.



CONTINUING SCHOLARS

Since launching the educational fund in 2018, our mission has grown far beyond providing scholarships to graduating high school seniors. Today, the OWJEF continues to expand its impact by investing in students at every stage of their educational journey.

Through initiatives like the OWJ Internship Initiative, we support scholars in securing paid summer internships aligned with their career goals. Our Oscar Juniors program has also continued to thrive, partnering with local elementary schools and First Security Bank to reward students for academic excellence, strong character, and consistent attendance through student savings contributions.

Building on that momentum, we introduced the OWJ Continuing Scholars Grant, extending our support to current college students as they pursue their degrees. As we gather for the 2026 Gala, we remain committed to doing even more—creating opportunities, opening doors, and continuing a legacy that empowers the next generation.



Eryn Carter
University of Arkansas at Fayetteville



Brooklyn Hayes
University of Central Arkansas



Mattison Wiley
University of Central Arkansas



Anders Tillman
University of Missouri at Columbia

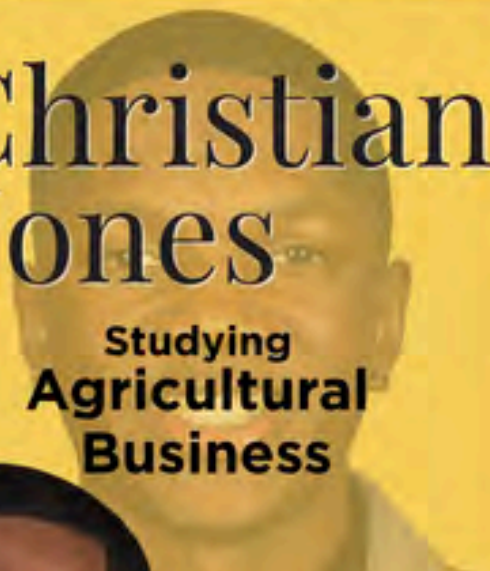
ERNEST LEVERETT VOCATIONAL SCHOLARS

This year, we are proud to introduce something new! The Ernest Leverett Vocational Scholarship. Because success doesn't follow just one path.

Ernest Leverett, a graduate of S.A. Jones High School and a United States Marine, dedicated his life to mastering his craft and building structures that strengthened communities across Arkansas. For over six decades, his work reflected skill, discipline, and lasting impact.

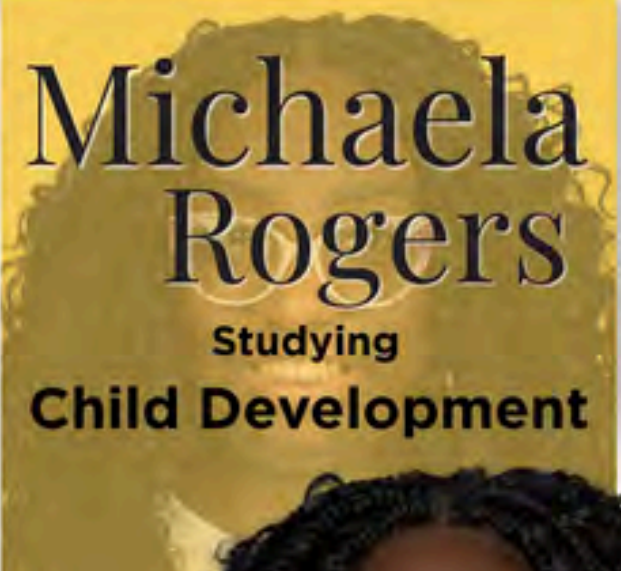
This scholarship honors students who carry that same spirit—those pursuing trade and vocational education, building their futures with purpose and pride.

What began nine years ago as a vision has grown into a movement—one that continues to open doors, uplift students, and create lasting change.



Christian
Jones

Studying
**Agricultural
Business**



Michaela
Rogers

Studying
Child Development



Ebony Mitchell



Ebony, a proud Arkansas native from Harrison, has built a career defined by leadership, service, and advocacy. With a strong background in the arts, business, and community engagement, she brings a dynamic perspective shaped by both professional excellence and a lifelong commitment to making a difference. Growing up, Ebony spent much of her time dancing and performing across the United States, experiences that helped shape her confidence, creativity, and passion for connecting with others.

Ebony earned her Bachelor's degree in Business Marketing from the University of Central Arkansas in 2019. Later she obtained a Master of Business Administration with an emphasis in Health Administration from John Brown University in 2022. Her academic accomplishments reflect her dedication to leadership, innovation, and service-oriented work.

Her commitment to advocacy became even more visible when she was crowned Miss Arkansas 2022, representing the state on the national stage at the Miss America Competition. For nearly a decade, she has worked to raise awareness about online safety, partnering with the Arkansas Department of Education and elected officials to provide training and resources for educators and students across the state. She is also a proud member of Leadership Greater Little Rock Class XL.

In recognition of her leadership and service, Sarah Huckabee Sanders appointed Ebony to the Arkansas 250 Commission. Today, she serves as the Director of External Affairs for the Arkansas Advanced Energy Association, where she continues to build partnerships and advocate for initiatives that strengthen communities across Arkansas.

2026 OWJEF Gala Keynote Speaker

SPEAKER

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Suzanne Yee



Michael Manning



Ebony Mitchell



April 11, 2026

Dear Friends, Supporters, and Honored Guests,

On behalf of the City of Little Rock, it is a privilege to extend warm greetings to each of you as you gather for the 9th Annual Oscar Washington, Jr. Scholarship Gala. This special occasion is a meaningful celebration of legacy, leadership, and the transformative power of education, as we honor outstanding student scholarship recipients and recognize our Educators of the Year.



This evening stands as a testament to the enduring impact of Oscar Washington, Jr. A man whose life was grounded in faith, service, and a deep commitment to uplifting others. His example as a devoted servant leader, mentor, and community pillar continues to inspire through the work of the Oscar Washington, Jr. Educational Fund. By investing in the next generation, this initiative carries forward a legacy rooted in compassion, purpose, and opportunity.

We are also honored to welcome our distinguished keynote speaker, Ebony Mitchell, whose journey reflects excellence, advocacy, and a steadfast commitment to service. From her academic achievements to her leadership across multiple sectors, including her role with the Arkansas Advanced Energy Association, she has consistently used her platform to empower others and strengthen communities. Her work in advancing online safety, her service as Miss Arkansas 2022, and her continued leadership across the state exemplify the very spirit of this evening's celebration. We are grateful for the inspiration she brings as she shares her story and vision for the future.

To the scholarship recipients, tonight we celebrate your dedication, perseverance, and bright potential. You are a reflection of what is possible when opportunity meets determination. To our educators, your commitment to shaping minds and nurturing growth does not go unnoticed. Your influence reaches far beyond the classroom and into the future of our community.

Thank you to the Washington family, the organizers, and all supporters who continue to honor this remarkable legacy through your generosity and dedication. Because of you, lives are being changed, and futures are being shaped.

May this evening be filled with pride, inspiration, and a renewed commitment to service, leadership, and excellence.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, which appears to read "Frank Scott, Jr.", is positioned below the word "Sincerely,".

Mayor Frank Scott, Jr.
City of Little Rock

Thank You!

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